remained in the practices of rival religious orders'. In the 1660s, Frenchman François Bernier knew nothing about Buddhism even after spending a decade in India. He called it 'a seventh sect' of Hinduism, whose few 'adherents are despised and hated, censured as irreligious and atheistical, and lead a life peculiar to themselves'. In the next two centuries, even these few adherents would disappear.

It is often said that ancient Indians were not interested in history, that their accounts of the past are inseparable from myth. Such accounts are indeed common but they're not the whole story. Early Pali texts, especially from Sri Lanka, suggest that Indian Buddhism too had fostered a sober chronicling of the past. This is a lot closer to 'proper history' than the Brahminical chronicles. 'The disappearance of Buddhism from India,' writes Omvedt, also led to 'the disappearance of some of the most valuable Indian historiography, and a deep Brahmanic bias in the existing records'.[32]

The Demise of Nalanda

Many history books and Internet sites today confidently state that c. 1200 CE, Nalanda was put to a brutal and decisive end by Bakhtiyar Khilji (not to be confused with Alauddin Khilji who lived a hundred years later and was caricatured in the 2018 film *Padmaavat*). Bakhtiyar Khilji (d. 1206) was a Turkic commander in the army of Qutb-ud-din Aibak (1150–1210), and was sent to conquer Bihar and Bengal.[33] He allegedly looted and burned Nalanda Mahavihara and killed hundreds or even thousands of its monks. 'Official guides' offer this story to visitors with lurid accounts of how Nalanda's great library smouldered for six long months. Unfortunately, this story is based on very little evidence.

That Khilji sacked Nalanda is inferred mainly from three sources. The first is sections of a few walls in a couple of monasteries where the bricks show fire damage; in other areas and in one monastery's courtyard, archaeologists have also found ash and charcoal. Fire was then commonly used for cooking, heating and lighting. The said damages could've been caused, before or after Khilji, by accidental fires that historians believe have occurred at various times in Nalanda's long history. For example, a stone